

Asim Shahzad

AI Expert & Technical Leader · Architecture · Agentic Systems · Delivery & Transformation · Advisory

Versatile senior AI practitioner turning 20 years of enterprise delivery and customer transformation into production AI

Birmingham, UK · Remote / hybrid · Right to work: UK

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PROFILE

A versatile senior AI practitioner who architects, builds, leads delivery, and advises, pairing 20 years of enterprise solution design with two years building production-grade AI. I find the gap between what a business is trying to achieve and what its tooling allows, design the right solution against recognised reference architectures, and ship something stakeholders can act on, fast. Equally at home in the architecture diagram, the codebase, the delivery plan and the boardroom.

I architect to the frameworks enterprise teams actually use, Microsoft Cloud Adoption Framework and Well-Architected, Azure AI Foundry/Azure OpenAI reference architectures, and the Responsible AI Standard mapped to the NIST AI Risk Management Framework. I treat the model as the easy 10%; the 90% that earns enterprise trust is the scaffolding: landing zones, identity, data grounding, private networking, content-safety guardrails, observability and governance. Platform-agnostic on technology; deliberately model-agnostic on AI.

WHAT I BRING

- **Ships, not slideware.** Two live AI products plus enterprise client architectures delivered end-to-end, from business gap to working solution stakeholders can use.
- **Architect, builder and advisor in one.** Comfortable owning the design, writing the code (AI-assisted), running the delivery plan and setting AI strategy with senior stakeholders.
- **Enterprise-grade by default.** Fluent across Azure AI Foundry; CAF, Well-Architected, Responsible AI / NIST AI RMF. I deliver the 90% of scaffolding that earns trust, not just a demo.
- **20 years of turning ambiguity into shipped outcomes.** At Cisco, BT, Vodafone, Telefónica and Capita. Now aimed squarely at AI. Model-agnostic, value-first, relentless about results.

SELECTED ENGAGEMENTS & SOLUTIONS

Client advisory via Fireforge Solutions, plus a portfolio of self-directed reference builds, each starting from a real business gap and ending in something stakeholders can act on.

AI Process-Automation Architecture, national infrastructure finance function *(client advisory, via Fireforge)*

Authored the solution architecture and Product Requirements Document for an Oracle-ERP-native month-end close automation suite (AR/AP/Procurement). Five components including job-chain orchestration, automated audit-evidence packaging and period-over-period variance detection. Designed to cut active staff time from 90 minutes to a 10–15 minute review task, remove single-point-of-failure dependencies and minimise licensing exposure. Delivered with governance framework, risk register, KPIs and a phased roadmap.

Client-Engagement Process Redesign & AI Architecture, professional-services firm *(client advisory, via Fireforge)*

Ran end-to-end process discovery across client onboarding, risk and compliance; recommended an AI architecture (document generation, workflow automation, AI analytics) integrated with Salesforce and SharePoint. Delivered as-is / to-be analysis, an implementation roadmap and SOPs to cut onboarding time and close compliance gaps.

Agent Assist, real-time AI co-pilot for contact-centre agents *(reference build)*

Gap: Five9 / Genesys / NICE charge premium fees for live-call agent assistance, pricing out smaller operators. Shipped: live transcript ingestion, intent detection, sentiment tracking, escalation flagging, suggested responses and RAG retrieval against the operator's own knowledge base, plus a live-demo mode. Next.js · TypeScript · Claude API · local vector embeddings.

SIP Troubleshooter, AI assistant for diagnosing SIP signalling faults *(reference build)*

Gap: SIP fault-finding ties up senior engineering hours on patterns that recur weekly. Shipped: drag-and-drop upload of text traces and binary pcap captures (decoded with scapy), automatic classification of common UC failure modes (488

codec mismatch, 503, 407 trunk auth, 486, registration failures) and structured remediation grounded in real UK carrier behaviour. Python · Streamlit · scapy.

Morning Brief, autonomous daily intelligence agent *(reference build · deployed live)*

Gap: leaders start the day blind to what moved overnight in their market and inbox. Shipped: an agent-native daily brief I built and deployed on my own cloud stack, wired live to Gmail and Google Calendar to fold the day's mail highlights and schedule into a single view, then runs an "AI radar", three research sub-agents working in parallel across news, tools and market, doing dated web research with freshness and confidence tags, and synthesises everything into one short ping plus a full written brief, delivered automatically each morning via a Telegram bot and email. Next.js · Supabase · Vercel (live deploy) · Claude API · Exa/Firecrawl · multi-agent orchestration.

Nexus v1.1, AI solution-architecture assistant *(concept prototype)*

Gap: turning a discovery call into a structured solution proposal costs senior architects days of manual work. Designed and prototyped a prompt-engineered AI assistant that turns a raw discovery-call transcript into a structured, consulting-grade solution-architecture pack, a stakeholder power map with engagement strategy, functional and non-functional requirements, a risk register, a multi-layer target architecture and supporting diagrams, output as a polished, client-shareable document. A working concept that shows how the discovery-to-proposal workflow can be compressed into a single AI pass, built to enterprise consulting standards and applicable to any complex engagement.

AI Contract Triage Co-pilot · self-initiated build, 2026 · live demo *(client advisory, via Fireforge)*

Problem: in-house legal teams read every routine contract by hand, so the review queue backs up at quarter-end. Reframed the problem from "summarise contracts" to triage contracts. Auto-clearing the 80% boilerplate so lawyers spend judgement only on the 20% that needs it. Designed and built a self-contained web app and a structured-JSON engine that classifies each contract, compares every clause to a configurable playbook, drafts redlines, and writes a one-page reviewer memo. Engineered trust-first guardrails a legal team would accept: nothing is auto-approved, low-confidence items escalate to a named human. Directed AI coding agents end-to-end and ran a separate adversarial QA agent to stress-test the output, fixing every defect before shipping a live, zero-install demo on GitHub Pages.

EXPERIENCE

Fireforge Solutions Ltd, Founder & AI Architect/Delivery & Transformation Lead Mar 2024 – Present

- Independent AI architecture practice; advise enterprises on where modern AI delivers measurable value and design solutions against vendor reference architectures (Microsoft CAF / Well-Architected / Foundry).
- Delivered the client engagements and reference solutions above, full discovery, solution design, governance and stakeholder-ready documentation.
- Design assistant workflows using RAG, system-prompt orchestration, multi-agent patterns (manager-worker, tool-using agents) and evaluation loops; benchmark Claude and OpenAI models for response validation, safety guardrails and iterative improvement.
- AI Contract Triage Co-pilot (2026): Built a playbook-driven triage tool that clears boilerplate contracts and escalates the exceptions to a human, cutting first-pass legal review to minutes. Designed the system, orchestrated AI build agents plus an adversarial QA pass, and shipped a live zero-install demo.

Telefónica Tech UK&I, UCaaS 3rd Line Engineer/Solution Support (Contract) Nov 2021 – Mar 2024

- Recognised for turning around challenging key accounts, rebuilt trust across customers, service delivery and engineering.
- Supported the introduction of AI-enabled contact-centre capabilities, including Five9 Agent Assist GenAI features.
- Designed and supported SIP-based private-cloud solutions integrated with Gamma and Colt carriers; led complex SIP signalling, media and network escalations.
- Delivered solution design, implementation and pre-sales across Cisco UC and contact-centre platforms.

Red Box, PBX / Contact Centre Engineer (Contract) May 2021 – Nov 2021

- Validated integrations between call-recording platforms and enterprise systems (Cisco, Avaya, Genesys, Mitel, Zoom); supported QA / dev lab stability for customer deployments.

Worcestershire Acute Hospitals NHS Trust, Cisco UC Engineer (Contract) May 2020 – Nov 2020

- Consultancy on the Cisco UC estate: migration planning, platform audits and a roadmap aligned to clinical and business requirements in a critical healthcare environment.

Intuitive Systems and Networks, Technical Consultant (Contract)

Nov 2018 – Jan 2019

- Audited client telephony and network environments for 13 UK sites (LAN, WAN, wireless, UCS); produced solution recommendations aligned to Cisco best practices for performance, resilience and scalability.

Vodafone, Solution Architect, New Product Development (Contract)

Oct 2016 – Jan 2017

- Solution design for Cisco Hosted Collaboration Solution (50,000+ endpoints); translated business requirements into designs, evaluated vendors on functional and commercial fit, and presented on call security and encryption.

Cisco Systems, Network Consulting Engineer (Contract)

Mar 2015 – Jun 2016

- Consultancy for Cisco Hosted Collaboration Solutions on large-scale enterprise deployments; high-level escalation management with Cisco TAC.

Earlier (2005–2015): UC and network solution delivery at BT, Capita and Softcat. Full history on request.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **AI & GenAI:** LLMs, prompt engineering, RAG (vector retrieval, embeddings, chunking), agentic/multi-agent design (manager-worker, tool-using), task decomposition, orchestration, memory integration, evaluation & validation loops, content-safety guardrails. Anthropic Claude (Console/Code/API), OpenAI, N8N, Cassidy, TypingMind.
- **Cloud & AI Architecture Frameworks:** Microsoft CAF & Well-Architected, Azure AI Foundry/Azure OpenAI reference architectures, M365 Copilot governance, Microsoft Responsible AI Standard, NIST AI Risk Management Framework; landing zones, identity (Entra ID), data governance (Purview), private networking, observability.
- **AI Strategy & Product:** AI use-case discovery, market-gap identification, business-requirements analysis, roadmap planning, stakeholder alignment, adoption strategy; strong focus on measurable business value over technology novelty.
- **Solution Architecture:** Discovery & requirements analysis, HLD/LLD, as-is/to-be process design, trade-off analysis, roadmaps, pre-sales.
- **Development:** Python (Pandas, NumPy), TypeScript/Next.js, SQL, APIs; AI-assisted development (Claude Code, Cursor, Replit, Vercel); no-code/automation (Zapier, Airtable, Glide); GitHub, Jupyter.
- **Enterprise Comms:** Cisco UC, UCaaS, contact-centre (Five9, Genesys, Webex CC), SIP signalling, codec negotiation, carrier trunking (Gamma, Colt, BT).

TRAINING & CERTIFICATIONS

- **Oxford Artificial Intelligence Programme**, Saïd Business School, University of Oxford (2022)
- **AI Data Science Professional**, Data Science Infinity (2023)
- **AI & Advanced Product Management Certifications**, Product Faculty (Miqdad Jaffer, Product Lead OpenAI, Cohorts 4–7; Jennifer Liu, ex-Google), 2024–2025
- **Claude Code & Agent-Native series:** Claude Code 101, Claude Code in Action, Install an Agent-Native OS in One Day with Claude Code (Cohorts 1–2), 2026
- **Maven AI programmes:** Master Market-Ready Agentic AI Workflows (Cohorts 3–7), AI Agent Bootcamp (Marily Nika, Google), How to Scale a Business with AI & Agentic Workflows, AI for Business Leaders (Allie K. Miller), Code with AI, No-code + AI, AI Engineering Essentials, 2024–2026
- **Business Development**, Dent Global: Business Development Training & Campaign-Driven Enterprise (Daniel & Andrew Priestley), 2016
- **Cisco (renewable)**, Collaboration Specialist (350-801), DevNet Associate (200-901), CCNA (200-301), 2020–2022

EDUCATION & INTERESTS

Education: BTEC National Diploma, Business & Finance (1995)

Interests: AI and emerging technologies · educational innovation and the future of learning · continuous personal and professional development · health, fitness and mental resilience.